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Refining the Acoustics of the Heart

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From *The Discerning Heart: Exploring the Christian Path*, 2006

Listen carefully . . . with the ear of your heart.
—Prologue, *Rule of Saint Benedict*

It is only with the heart that one sees rightly;
what is essential is invisible to the eyes.
—Antoine de Saint Exupéry, *The Little Prince*

To know something important "by heart" is an experience of wholeness. The term *heart* is a traditional image for a way of perceiving, feeling, and loving that engages the total person. To Saint Augustine, the word signifies "our whole interior and spiritual life, and it includes mind and will, knowledge and love."[1] Heart, when used to symbolize spiritual discernment, indicates that following God is not something primarily heady, action oriented, or moralistic. Rather, it is a matter of being caught up in a dynamic, loving relationship with God and others. A heart-centered approach to discernment is holistic.

In the New Testament, the word *holistic* (from the Greek *holus*) means "total" or "whole," as in the story of the widow's mite, in which Jesus commends the woman for putting her *holon ton biou* ("all she had to live on") into the treasury (Mark 12:44). Like the dance called the hokey pokey, which invites us to "put your whole self in," holistic discernment invites us to put our whole self into the process. A holistic approach is inclusive and takes seriously the knowledge-bearing capacity not only of the mind but also of the body, emotions, senses, imagination, feelings, intuition, and dreams. "Two fundamentally different ways of knowing interact to construct our mental life," states psychologist Daniel Goleman. "One, the rational mind, is the mode of comprehension we are typically conscious of: more prominent in awareness, thoughtful, able to ponder and reflect. But alongside that there is another system of knowing: impulsive and powerful, if sometimes illogical—the emotional mind."[2] The research findings in the field of neurology, Goleman argues, show that how well we do in life is determined by both rational and emotional intelligence. "The old paradigm," he states, "held an ideal of reason freed of the pull of emotion. The new paradigm urges us to harmonize head and heart."[3]

Holistic discernment revolves around a form of knowing that goes beyond cold rationality. This mode of knowing is reflected in the Hebrew verb *yadah*, signifying the kind of intimate knowledge resulting from the unification of intellect, feeling, and actions. Ignatian spirituality speaks of it as *sentir*, a felt knowledge that pervades the whole of one's being. As Paul Tillich puts it, it is not so much "grasping the truths of faith" but "being grasped by the Truth of faith." In his autobiography, C. S. Lewis provides a vivid description of a time when philosophical and intellectual constructs of Christianity came to life for him in this holistic way of knowing:

> As the dry bones shook and came together in that dreaded valley of Ezekiel's, so now a philosophical theorem cerebrally entertained, began to stir and heave and throw off its gravecloths, and stood upright and became a living presence. I was to be allowed to play at philosophy no longer. . . . Total surrender, the absolute leap in the dark, were demanded.[4]

Holistic knowing enables us to "listen to the messages from all the self's aspects: the mind, the heart, the genitals, the viscera, the

spiritual sensitivities."[5] "Various forms of existential therapy value this holistic mode of knowing; these therapies try to restore the place of feelings where rationality has been the exclusive mode of operating. Gestalt therapy, for example, "undercuts language, the tool of thought, and clears the way for an approach that is explicitly *organismic*."[6]

An organismic approach is holistic because it places the body, with its movement and sensations, on the same level as the mind and its abstract thoughts and verbal symbols. This approach recognizes the body-spirit or psychosomatic unity of the person and affirms that bodily expressions often reveal interior states pertinent to making a choice. Hardly an esoteric concept, the psychosomatic unity of the person can be observed whenever bodily reactions reveal affective states. Blushing, sweaty palms, and accelerated heart rate are common examples of these physical manifestations of emotions. Gestalt therapists, for example, rely heavily on body language for an indication of psychological states. They generally believe that the body conveys how a person feels more truthfully than words. Because our bodily posture and gestures often unconsciously express our interior states, awareness of them can reveal what is going on in us.

Gestalt therapist James Simkin recounts a case that illustrates this organismic approach. Once, when working with a man struggling to decide whether to remain in a business venture recently begun with a friend, Simkin asked the client to imagine sticking with his business commitment. As the client imagined concretely what this option would entail, Simkin directed him to attend to his bodily sensations. When he imagined remaining with the business, the client's stomach tied up in knots. Then Simkin directed him to fantasize dropping the commitment. As the client did so, his stomach began to unravel and relax. The therapist then asked him to continue to shuttle between the two different fantasies, while simultaneously paying attention to his bodily reactions. As the client did so, he discovered a recurrent pattern: whenever he imagined staying with the business venture, his body was filled with stress; whenever he imagined abandoning the business deal, his body began to relax. Simkin concludes:

> Being able to self-validate what is the correct solution through one's own body language is a tremendous help in the economy of psychotherapy. Many of the transference and countertransference difficulties can be avoided, as well as the pitfalls of interpretation, through teaching oneself and one's patients how to use their symptoms—how to listen to their own body language.[7]

Simkin's case demonstrates how useful the data produced by the imagination, senses, bodily sensations, and feelings can be in decision-making. "My total organismic sensing of a situation is more trustworthy than my intellect," states psychologist Carl Rogers in support of a holistic approach. Testifying to this "wisdom of the organism," Rogers states: "As I gradually come to trust my total reactions more deeply, I find that I can use them to guide my thinking. . . . I think of it as trusting the totality of my experience, which I have learned to suspect is wiser than my intellect. It is fallible I am sure, but I believe it to be less fallible than my conscious mind alone."[8]

Attention to Interior Movements

What psychologists such as Rogers and Simkin say of decision-making is equally true of discernment. A holistic approach to discernment maintains that we must be alert to how we are being touched by God in all areas of our lives, because no aspect escapes the influence of the divine Spirit. When thought is the coin of the realm, other important sources of information, like feelings, bodily reactions, and intuitions, can be overlooked. A purely rational approach to discernment is impoverished because it fails to recognize God's influence in religious and affective experiences. Like holistic decision-making, good discernment must take into account one's total, organismic sensing of a situation. A society dominated by science and technology often mistrusts feelings and touts a coldly dispassionate approach as the only intelligent way to make decisions. Nevertheless, recent neurological findings have verified what common sense has told us long

ago: feelings have a crucial role in navigating the endless stream of decisions we must make for satisfying living.

> While strong feelings can create havoc in reasoning, the *lack* of awareness of feeling can also be ruinous, especially in weighing the decisions on which our destiny largely depends: what career to pursue, whether to stay with a secure job or switch to one that is riskier but more interesting, whom to date or marry, where to live, which apartment to rent or house to buy—and on and on through life. Such decisions cannot be made well through sheer rationality; they require gut feeling, and the emotional wisdom garnered through past experiences. Formal logic alone can never work as the basis for deciding whom to marry or trust or even what job to take; *these are realms where reason without feeling is blind*[9] (emphasis added).

Ignatian spirituality goes further in asserting the importance of feelings by connecting our emotional awareness with our ability to decipher how we are being moved by God. Ignatius "came to recognize that human experiences of joy and desolation, of enthusiasm and depression, of light and darkness, are not just human emotions which vary like the wind in a storm, but are the means by which we recognize the movements within our spirit stirred by the Spirit of Jesus."[10] Thus, in the *Spiritual Exercises* Ignatius instructs the director of a retreat to focus on the interior movements and experiences of the retreatant. If the retreatant reports not being affected by any movements, either of consolation or desolation, it is important that the director inquire into this (no. 6). For Ignatius, the director's central question to the retreatant throughout the experience of the *Spiritual Exercises* is: "How were you *moved* in prayer?"

Integrating Reason, Affect, and Religious Experience

Ignatius's approach to discerning life choices reflects the organismic approach of Gestalt therapy and can be considered as an early form of holistic decision-making. Like the organismic approach of Gestalt therapy, Ignatian guidelines for deciding or "making an election" emphasize the integration of thought, affectivity, imagination, and sensation. Ignatius's *sentir* or felt knowledge is equivalent to Gestalt therapy's idea of "emotional insights."[11] These emotional insights help decision-making because they are based on an expanded awareness of one's relationship with the environment, accompanied by positive feelings and a sense of discovery.[12] For example, when an obese person is able to persevere in a weight-loss program for an extended period, he may happily discover that his power to control his eating is greater than he had thought. Or a student struggling with self-doubts may realize, with the help of a counselor, that her consistent success in science and mathematics classes makes it realistic for her to dream about being a physician like her mother. These examples of emotional insights differ greatly from purely intellectual insights that have no impact on life decisions because they are not rooted in one's actual experiences. The case cited by Simkin above is a clear illustration of how Gestalt therapists lead clients to emotional insight by teaching them how to attend to their actual bodily reactions and emotions when deciding. In a similar way, Ignatius attempts to help retreatants making a decision detect God's influence as it impinges on their minds, hearts, and bodies.

Ignatius's Three Times of Making an Election

In the *Spiritual Exercises*, Ignatius describes three times or ways in which God can guide people faced with choice. The first time occurs when God "so moves and attracts the will that a devout soul without hesitation, or the possibility of hesitation, follows what has been manifested

to it" (no. 175). Ignatius cites the responses of Saint Paul and Saint Matthew to Christ's call in order to illustrate this first time of election. Phenomenologically, this first time can be viewed as a moment of peak religious experience when individuals feel overwhelmed by an inner sense of certainty about their decisions. At such moments they may experience something deep within "click into place," providing an intuitive sense of how they must proceed. Everything points in one direction, and they feel no contrary movement. Or they may perceive such a total congruence between their sense of internal requiredness (what they feel they must do) and God's will (what they think God wants of them) that the course to be followed is unambiguously clear. Sometimes, quite apart from any deliberation, a personal "moment of truth" can spring suddenly upon the person without any antecedent cause, like a forceful flash of insight, removing any further need for deliberating.[13]

The second time of decision-making suggested by Ignatius emphasizes the knowledge-bearing capacity of feelings. It occurs when individuals must rely on their affective states of consolation or desolation to detect the influence of God regarding the decision to be made (no. 176). In the case of people progressing earnestly along the spiritual path,[14] Ignatius understands consolation as a complex of positive feelings that encourages, supports, and confirms a prospective decision as being "right." He sees desolation as a complex of negative feelings that discourages, questions, and calls into doubt a prospective decision, suggesting that it is "not right." The assumption underlying this second time of election is that emotions can be indicators of God's guidance.

The third time of decision-making highlights the process of reasoning (nos. 177–87).[15] Picturing oneself on one's deathbed and recalling God's purpose for creating us (that we might live in loving relationship with God by praising, reverencing, and serving God [no. 23]), the person is asked to list the pros and cons of various options (no. 186). This third time presupposes that God's guiding influence can be felt in the process of reasoning.[16] Like the values-clarification exercise that asks people what they would do if they had only a week to live, this Ignatian method relies on the truth that can come at

death's door to provide a perspective for present choices. In other words, it asks people to anticipate which decision they would ratify or regret when facing death. In this third time of election, Ignatius also provides an example of heeding one's inner wisdom when he suggests imagining a person coming to us for help in making a choice similar to one we are facing. We should listen carefully to what we counsel this person to do and then follow our own advice (no. 185). This Ignatian exercise contains a twofold value: it increases clarity through objectification (telling our own story in the third person) and it encourages us to honor our inner authority.[17]

The genius of Ignatius, theologian Michael J. Buckley points out, was not that he counted transpersonal influences, or the attractions of affectivity, or the process of thinking as critical factors in securing the guidance of God. Others also shared this inclusive view. Ignatius's explanation of the dynamics of these three often interrelating factors within a person's religious experience is unique. "What Ignatius provided," maintains Buckley, "was a structure within which each of these finds a significant place; none is dismissed out of hand. A coordination among them is established so that they reach an integrity of effect and one is taught how to recognize and reply to each."[18]

Choice and Confirmation: The Twofold Ignatian Dynamic

The phrase *integrity of effect* aptly describes the desired outcome of Ignatian discernment. Presuming the person is genuinely committed to doing the will of God and is free from inordinate attachments that destroy freedom, the decision is integral if it emanates from an integration of feelings and thoughts. Ignatius sought this integration by building into the second and third times of decision-making a complementary dynamic. He directs the person who makes a decision based on the rational approach of the third time to seek affective confirmation by prayerfully attending to his or her feelings as suggested by the second time of election (no. 183). In other words, following a

decision the person should stay in close touch with the feelings that arise as a result of the decision and determine whether they confirm the rightness of the choice or cast doubt on it. After a period of testing, if positive feelings (for example, peace, joy, hope, confidence) dominate, it is clear that affectivity has joined with intelligence to produce a harmonious effect. However, if negative and disturbing feelings (such as doubt, fear, anxiety, discouragement) persist, then a closure would seem premature and the person should continue the process until an inner harmony is produced through the alliance of head and heart.

Conversely, a person who makes a decision based on the affective approach of the second time should also seek rational confirmation through a method of the third time. William Peters, in his commentary on the *Spiritual Exercises*, cites the *Directory of 1599* to substantiate this point. He notes that Juan de Polanco, a close friend of Ignatius, called the second time of election "more excellent" than the third, but adds that it might be wise to check the result of an election made in this time by one of the methods of the third.[19] Concretely speaking, when we make a decision based on a pattern of consolation surrounding a specific choice, we are still encouraged to strengthen that choice by thinking of all the pros that support that choice. At this point in the discernment process, we should play down the cons and put them on the back burner and not permit them to sabotage the decision that has just been made peacefully through consoling experiences in prayer. This approach allows us to invest wholeheartedly in the direction we have chosen in consolation without being hampered by any nagging voice of negativity. Of course, we need to monitor our ongoing experiences of consolation or desolation as we actually live out our choice in order to confirm its rightness or wrongness in concrete experience.[20] Choice and confirmation make up the two-part dynamic of the Ignatian method of discernment.

Clearly, the second time of decision-making, based on affectivity, and the third time, based on reasoning, were designed by Ignatius to function in a complementary dynamic. The Ignatian process seeks to ground life choices on felt knowledge, not on theoretical abstractions. This process, according to Ignatian scholar John Futrell, involves

paying attention simultaneously to "the continuity of thoughts during reflection, the concomitant feelings constantly reacting to these thoughts—feelings which confirm or call into question the orientation of the reflection—and the growing understanding which involves both the thoughts and feelings—felt-knowledge."[21]

Grounding Ignatius's Three Times of Election in Contemporary Thought

Ignatius's first time or way of making an election, when a person is so touched by God that he or she knows deeply the path to be followed without any need for deliberation, finds contemporary support in the distinction made between religious truth and scientific truth. Whereas truth-claims in science need to be backed up by reproducibility, a religious truth may be based on a single, unique, irrepeatable religious experience. According to the scientific method, a truth-claim can be empirically verified only if an experiment produces the same results over and over again under the same conditions or variables. A religious truth, however, requires no such reproducibility to establish its claim to validity.

According to psychologist Joseph R. Royce, "The scientific enterprise is objective and it moves in the direction of making generalizations. Religion, on the other hand, demands personal involvement or subjectivity. . . . It recognizes that such individual involvement may be unique rather than a general phenomenon."[22] Existential validation, not empirical verification, grounds a religious truth. Existential validation occurs when we experience deeply the meaning, significance, and well-being produced by what we know through a religious experience. Theologian Paul Tillich illustrates how such a religious truth can come in a powerful experience of being "struck by grace":

> Do you know what it means to be struck by grace? . . . We cannot transform our lives, unless we allow them to be transformed by the stroke of grace. It happens or it does not happen. And certainly it does

not happen if we try to force it upon ourselves, just as it shall not happen so long as we think, in our self-complacency, that we have no need of it. Grace strikes us when we are in great pain and restlessness. It strikes us when, year after year, the longed-for perfection of life does not appear, when despair destroys all joy and courage. Sometimes at that moment a shaft of light breaks into our darkness, and it is as though a voice were saying: "You are accepted. You are accepted," accepted by that which is greater than you, and the name of which you do not know. Do not ask for the name now, perhaps you will find it later. Do not try to do anything; do not perform anything; do not intend anything. Simply accept the fact that you are accepted. If that happens to us, we experience grace. . . . Sometimes it happens that we receive the power to say "yes" to ourselves, that peace enters into us and makes us whole, that self-hatred and self-contempt disappear, and that our self is reunited with itself. Then we can say that grace has come upon us.[23]

Tillich's description of the experience of being struck by grace resembles Ignatius's description of consolation without a previous cause. "I said without previous cause," states Ignatius, "that is, without any preceding perception or knowledge of any subject by which a soul might be led to such a consolation through its own acts of intellect and will" (no. 330). Like Tillich's description of grace, this consolation described by Ignatius is characterized by its total gift nature. Unlike scientific knowledge that is engendered by a controlled experiment, religious knowledge is simply received as a gift from God. "It belongs solely to the Creator to come into a soul, to leave it, to act upon it, to draw it wholly to the love of His Divine Majesty," states Ignatius in his "Rules for Discernment of Spirits" (no. 330). Those who make an election in Ignatius's first time have clearly been struck by an amazing grace that eliminates the need for any discernment process, since they sense deep within, without any doubt or contrary inner movement, the course they must pursue.

However, when such an experience of consolation is not accompanied by a deep clarity about choices to be made, it is critical to note Ignatius's caveat that people who have experienced consolation without a previous cause "must consider it very attentively, and must

cautiously distinguish the actual time of the consolation from the period which follows it. At such a time the soul is still fervent and favored with the grace and aftereffects of the consolation which has passed. In this second period the soul frequently forms various resolutions and plans which are not granted directly by God" (no. 336). In this time of "afterglow," the plans and choices we make cannot be attributed directly to God, as was the actual moment of consolation, but have their source in our own fallible human reasoning and judgments. As such, they are susceptible to error.

Ignatius's three times of making an election can also be further understood in light of the theological distinction between God's transcendent and immanent nature. This distinction underpins his three ways of being influenced by God in our discernment. The first time of election highlights the transcendent nature of God, while the second and third times of election emphasize the immanent nature of God. When we refer to God's transcendence, we are acknowledging the fact that God is illimitable Mystery, totally beyond and dissimilar to any created reality and far beyond our human comprehension. Sovereign over all of creation, God can intervene in our lives to influence our choices without the mediation of thoughts, feelings, and images. When we speak of God's immanence, we acknowledge that God communicates to us not through mystical or ecstatic experiences alone, but also through the normal human faculties of knowing and experiencing. When we acknowledge that God is both transcendent and immanent, we affirm God's indwelling presence within the world while maintaining that God is wholly other and irreducible to any aspect of creation.